

“Civilization begins with order, grows with liberty and dies with chaos” said Will Durant, a prominent American historian and philosopher.

The history of mankind is the history of various civilizations. Civilizations had various forms throughout history, often being peaceful or barbaric, large or small, gradual or abrupt. These different characteristics civilizations had was determined by the people in it, being social organizations formed between people.

Civilizations are created for people in the civilization to live a better life. For example, ancient civilizations were formed for the convenience of people, as it allowed them to have a certain profession with abundant food sources and economic opportunities. This has evolved over time, as the standard of living for humans has increased with technological advancements throughout history. This allowed civilizations to be distinctively different from each other, in the sense of infrastructure, classes, and ideology.

However, as there are creations of civilizations, there are also downfall of civilizations. According to the Cambridge dictionary, the definition of civilization is a “human society with its well developed social organizations, or the culture and way of life of a society or country at a particular period in time.” Within this definition of civilization, the collapse of civilization implies that the society lacks a well developed social organization, and the way of life of a society or country is not sustained and destroyed. A few causes of why civilizations fall down can be war, disease, natural disaster, economic collapse, and emergence of novel ideologies. Hence, civilizations collapse due to internal and external factors that cause chaos which affects the quality of life of the people, leading to a deterioration of social organization.

According to the definition of the collapse of a civilization formulated earlier, there are many historical examples of this process. For instance, the Aztec empire came to an end due to external factors. As the European conquerors, mainly represented as the Spanish, decided to conquer the Middle American region, the homeland of the Aztecs. The Aztec civilization faced war with a population with superior weaponry technology along with a devastating virus from the colonizers. This war gave consequences to the Aztecs, as the way of life of a society cannot be sustained, leading to the collapse of a social organization due to lack of people and peace. War, as one of the leading causes of the downfall of civilizations, has continued until contemporary times.

War is a significant factor responsible for the collapse of the civilizations. This is as in war times, the social organization, mainly the government, is not able to function normally. During war time, the government’s main focus and objective is to win the war and return to the original peaceful state, rather than the original priority of the government in a peaceful state. The different ministries of the government shift from their original work to work focused on the war. Thus, the social organization for the people is not able to function normally for a short period of time, unable to support and ensure the quality of life of the citizens.

Moreover, the way of life of the citizens and the members of the civilization cannot be sustained due to the ongoing conflict with another country. Which is as most of the population is

required to help the country to win the war, or evacuate for the maintenance of their lives and the population of the country.

The civilizations in war are impacted with global consequences. Their diplomatic relationships with the allies of the enemy civilization consequently worsens, as conventional wars are usually not a war between two countries, but also with the supporters mostly including global superpowers. This disconnection with the enemy alliance produces the outcome of being diplomatically and economically falling behind, and is impacted by imported goods. This creates an economic challenge for a country, leading them to have a non-sustainable life due to increased prices.

As such, war within a civilization creates destructive impacts on multiple aspects of the civilization. These are the examples of the process of a civilization heading towards its downfall, as the key parts composing the civilization is threatened. This usually led to the complete destruction of a civilization in traditional matters or civilization with a lot of difference in power, as the war mostly ended in the complete colonization of a civilization over another, as such in the case of the middle American civilizations and European countries during Napoleonic wars. However, in the conventional manners of the war, war can be a contribution of accelerating the process of the downfall of a civilization, but it does not mostly relate directly to the downfall of the civilization. This is as there are many more mediators around the world that do not want further conflicts between more countries such as the UN, which was demonstrated in the recent Russo-Ukrainian war.

As war is an obvious threat to the downfall of civilization, other external forces also lead to the downfall of civilizations.

Another example of an external factor for the downfall of a civilization is viruses. As with the same example of the Aztec empire, the smallpox brought by the colonizers had devastating effects on the citizens as almost half of the population in Tenochtitlán have died from it. This shows how the virus collapses civilizations as the life of the members of civilizations is sacrificed. This virus in the medieval times has directly affected the lives of people as there is no medical development to prevent the infection and deaths of the virus. However, although there is more medical development nowadays, diseases still create disturbance in the life of people such as limiting their social life and economical lifestyle, causing the downfall of civilization too. This can be seen in the case of COVID-19, as there were lockdowns and restrictions regarding going out.

Natural disasters, another external factor, have also led to the downfall of civilizations. The eruption of Mount Vesuvius in 79 CE led to the destruction of Pompeii, wiping out the entire city and its inhabitants. This example illustrates how powerful natural events are as they are capable of eliminating an entire civilization, disrupting their social and economic structures beyond repair.

By the cases of war, virus, and natural disaster it is evident that the downfall of civilization can be brought from external influences such as natural disasters. But, as these

factors become more manageable by the enhancement of technology, there are conventional threats to civilizations including internal reasons.

The modern emergence of novel ideologies has significantly impacted traditional civilizations, leading to their collapse. The collapse of civilization includes the termination of a civilization's organized system, including the way of life of the members of civilization, regarding culture. Furthermore, modern ideologies and movements alter these traditional values, causing internal conflicts leading to the collapse of civilization.

An example of this can be found in the modern feminist movements. Although the original ideology of feminism was social, economical, and political equality in different sexes, certain modern feminist views advocate women supremacy over men. Regardless of it, feminism challenges traditional gender roles, such as the traditional view of the husband working to support the family and the wife taking care of the household and giving birth. But due to the modern ideology of feminism appearing, this role is comprehended as stereotypical or outdated. This does not mean that the equality of different genders introduces problems, but rather the changes cause troubles amongst different members of society. This can be also seen in the modern emergence of the "career women". The effect of this change is both positive and negative like any other changes, as there was more gender-equal power in the marketplace due to more female workers but also lessened the birth rate as for women worker's decreased time for family. These changes do not harm the civilization critically as there are also benefits, but this creates different effects amongst the civilization, such as the conflict between the ones who support the idea and reject the idea. Unlike the change itself, the conflicts caused by the change, lead to the collapse of civilization.

Feminism and the occurrence of women workers are just an example of the change in traditional values in modern society. There are many more changes that are being implemented in the society today regarding equality of different backgrounds, which is creating a difference from the traditional society. These changes are often controversial, as it has both beneficial parts and non beneficial parts with different perspectives of different classes. Regardless of this, it is obvious that the emergence of modern ideologies have created a change in the traditional lifestyle of people, which creates challenges between the ones who believe in traditional lifestyle and those who accept the new ideologies.

Similarly, with the example of gender identity, as people are able to identify themselves as anything they want, it causes multiple changes in the traditional system of our civilization. A simple example of the negative effect of this ideology could be the decline in fertility rate due to increasing numbers of non-cross sex relationships. This decline in population can introduce threats of the downfall of civilization, but this can be a negative effect that ought to be solved considering the importance of gender identity. However, the influence of gender identity will change people's ideology regarding gender roles and gender itself, creating a colossal impact on the people's thought and their lifestyle. This will create an effect of the conflict between the members of civilizations who support the older ideologies and those who support the newer ideologies, causing confusion in the system of civilization. This means that although the people

can catch up with the new ideologies, the legislations and societal norms are not enough to, causing an effect of breaking the social rules while not making new ones due to the rapid changes of ideas. This causes malfunctioning of the civilization in terms of individual lifestyle and governmental function, inducing the collapse of the civilization.

Thus, our civilization is in danger. This danger is not caused by external reasons such as warfare or climate change, but rather the internal problems of the emergence of novel ideologies. Although there are various threats of the downfall of civilization due to external factors, it is likely that human civilization will overcome it.

For example, wars and diseases can create a struggle in civilization, but it is likely that it will be overcome within some time as shown throughout the history of World War II and COVID-19. There can be an elimination of the entire civilization with scenarios that include the annihilation in the scale of a continent or planet, but that is extremely unlikely to happen. And for these reasons, external threats are not enough to wipe out the current civilization. On the other hand, the internal reason has enough influence to collapse a civilization due to its recent emergence and the level of conflict it can trigger within a civilization, shown from examples regarding sensitive topics such as gender and equality.

Therefore, civilizations collapse due to external and internal factors. External factors have contributed to the downfall of civilization in the past, but internal factors are much of a threat in conventional civilizations. These internal factors are usually new ideologies that are capable of shaping the civilization, such as feminism or gender identity movement. And for that reason, the loss of a cultural foundation can make it more difficult for civilizations to maintain its normal functionality and start declining.